CSE0001 – Digital Literacy | Task 5 – Part A

Cybercrime Case Study: Phishing

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Crime Type	Phishing
Scenario Type	Realistic Fictional Scenario
Primary Target	College students and young professionals in India

What Is Phishing?

Phishing is a type of online fraud where an attacker pretends to be a trustworthy source — a bank, a government body, a university, or even a friend — in order to trick someone into handing over sensitive information. That information could be a password, an OTP, bank account details, or personal ID data. The attacker then uses whatever they've collected to steal money or take over accounts.

How It Happens — Step by Step

Here is a realistic scenario of how a phishing attack might target a first-year engineering student in India:

1. The student receives a WhatsApp message from an unknown number. The message says: "Congratulations! You have been selected for the National Student Scholarship Portal. Click the link to claim your Rs. 15,000 grant before the deadline." There is a link attached that looks official.
2. The link opens a website that looks almost exactly like a real government scholarship portal — same logo, same colour scheme, same font. The only difference is the URL, which says "scholarship-india-gov.in" instead of the real "scholarships.gov.in". Most people do not notice.
3. The fake site asks the student to fill in their Aadhaar number, bank account number, and IFSC code so that the "scholarship amount can be transferred directly."
4. To make it feel even more legitimate, the site then asks for the OTP sent to the student's registered mobile number — claiming it is needed for "verification." The student enters it.
5. Within minutes, the attacker — who now has the bank account details and OTP — initiates an unauthorised transaction. The student loses money from their account before they realise anything has gone wrong.

Who Is Usually Targeted?

Phishing attacks often go after people who are new to digital financial tools and who may not yet be confident enough to question something that looks official. First-year college students are a common target — they have just started using UPI and internet banking independently, they are often looking for scholarships and part-time opportunities, and they are less likely to pause and